

AFRICAN HUMANITARIAN AGENCY

Foundational Operational Framework 3

Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework

1. Purpose

This framework sets out how the African Humanitarian Agency (AfHA) will organise, govern, share, analyse and use humanitarian data and information across continental, regional and national levels. Its purpose is to ensure that AfHA can support timely, evidence-based and coordinated humanitarian action through interoperable data systems and disciplined information management, while respecting Member State ownership, data protection, institutional sensitivities and humanitarian principles.

A second purpose of this framework is to define AfHA's Minimum Viable Information Function. AfHA is a new institution; therefore, it cannot and should not attempt to build a fully-fledged continental information architecture from the outset. Instead, it requires a practical, phased and realistic baseline capability that will allow it to receive, verify, synthesise and disseminate critical information from day one, while gradually expanding towards a more mature and integrated continental information function.

The framework therefore provides both a strategic data and interoperability architecture and a pragmatic first operating model for AfHA's initial years.

2. Rationale

Humanitarian action in Africa is already supported by a wide range of information systems and technical actors. These include national disaster management systems, meteorological and hydrological services, public health surveillance platforms, displacement monitoring systems, REC mechanisms, AU early warning systems, Africa CDC, and partner information products. Yet these systems are often fragmented, unevenly accessible, differently formatted and weakly connected across scales. In many crises, the problem is not the complete absence of data, but rather the absence of trusted interoperability, shared standards, timely synthesis and common decision support.

AfHA is being established precisely to strengthen continental and regional coherence. To do this credibly, it must be able to build a common operating picture from multiple data streams without duplicating the mandates of technical agencies or overriding national ownership of primary data. It must also be able to support coordination and action during both sudden-onset and slow-onset crises, including cross-border events, anticipatory action and complex emergencies.

The challenge is therefore twofold. First, AfHA must define how it will interoperate with existing systems across the continent. Second, it must define the minimum information capabilities it needs internally to perform its mandate from the beginning. This framework addresses both requirements.

In designing its information and data architecture, AfHA draws deliberately on the accumulated practice of comparable regional humanitarian coordination and civil protection mechanisms elsewhere in the world. The most instructive lessons from those experiences are the following. First, that a tiered and graduated information product suite, from rapid initial alerts through regular situation reporting to periodic strategic reviews and seasonal outlooks, is one of the most visible and valued services a continental coordination mechanism can provide, and one of the earliest proofs of operational relevance. Second, that a 24/7 monitoring and watch function, however lightly staffed, is qualitatively different from a mechanism that only produces information reactively when crises are already under way: always-on monitoring is what allows a coordination centre to warn before impact rather than report after it. Third, that sex, age and disability disaggregated data standards must be embedded in information systems from the design stage, not retrofitted later, if they are to meaningfully shape humanitarian decision-making. Fourth, that impact-based forecasting, connecting meteorological and hazard probability forecasts to their likely humanitarian consequences, is the data bridge between early warning and anticipatory action, and is the dimension of continental information management with the greatest potential to save lives if done well. This framework incorporates all four of these lessons, adapted to AfHA's mandate, resources and phased development trajectory.

3. Objectives

This framework pursues the following objectives:

- Define AfHA's humanitarian data and information role within Africa's wider institutional ecosystem.
- Establish principles and standards for interoperability between AfHA, AU systems, RECs, Member States and partners.
- Define AfHA's Minimum Viable Information Function for the first phase of operationalisation.
- Clarify the institutional architecture for information management across Headquarters, Regional Centres and national interfaces.
- Establish minimum datasets, information products and data flows required for coordination, preparedness, anticipatory action and emergency response.
- Define governance rules for data access, quality assurance, sharing, security and protection.
- Provide a phased roadmap from minimum viable information capability to mature continental interoperability.
- Create the foundation for related SOPs on data collection, validation, information products, partner information exchange and crisis reporting.

4. Scope

This framework applies to all humanitarian data and information functions of AfHA across the full crisis cycle. It covers the following categories of data and information:

- risk, hazard and vulnerability information
- continental and regional early warning information
- exposure and impact information
- displacement and population movement information
- operational coordination information
- response tracking and gap information
- logistics and corridor information
- anticipatory action trigger information
- regional and continental humanitarian situation analysis
- internal and external information products
- information sharing arrangements with national, regional, continental and global actors
- AfHA Headquarters
- AfHA Regional Centres
- the AfHA situation room
- information management and analysis staff
- operational and coordination staff using humanitarian information
- designated national focal institutions
- RECs and Regional Mechanisms
- relevant AU technical entities and specialised institutions
- approved humanitarian and technical partners where information exchange is required.

This framework does not replace specialised technical systems owned by other institutions. It defines how AfHA will connect to, use and complement them.

5. Normative basis

This framework is grounded in the following instruments, policies and frameworks:

- the Statute of the African Humanitarian Agency
- the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework

- the Institutional Operational Agility Framework
- the Preparedness, Anticipatory Action, and Risk Reduction Framework
- the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework
- the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework
- relevant AU and national instruments on early warning, public administration, disaster management and data governance
- the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection (Malabo Convention) and the African Union Data Policy Framework
- accepted international guidance on humanitarian data responsibility, including the IASC Operational Guidance on Data Responsibility in Humanitarian Action
- applicable host country, AU and national rules relating to confidentiality, records and information protection.

Framework 3 is the information-enabling framework for AfHA's wider operational architecture. It defines data domains, information products, exchange routines, validation procedures, governance rules and minimum technology requirements. It does not replace the companion frameworks that define coordination structures, financing decisions, capacity and surge systems, preparedness and anticipatory action procedures, or political advocacy and visibility pathways. Where this framework refers to those functions, it does so only to define the information basis required to support them.

6. Guiding principles

Nine guiding principles govern AfHA's approach to humanitarian data and information management. These principles apply to all information functions, all data systems and all exchange relationships, and they inform the interpretation of every subsequent section of this framework.

6.1 Member State data ownership

Primary national data remains under the ownership and authority of Member States and relevant national institutions. AfHA does not assume unrestricted ownership of data merely because it receives or uses it. In practice this means that AfHA always acknowledges primary data sources, seeks appropriate consent or exchange arrangements before using sensitive national datasets, and does not republish or redistribute national data in ways that contradict the terms under which it was shared.

6.2 Interoperability over duplication

AfHA prioritises linking and harmonising existing data systems rather than creating unnecessary parallel ones. The continent already possesses significant information infrastructure in meteorology, public health, displacement monitoring, agricultural early warning and conflict tracking. AfHA's value lies in connecting these systems and making their outputs mutually useful, not in replicating them with less expertise and fewer resources. This principle applies to mandates and systems, not to sources. AfHA will not duplicate the mandate of any institution, but it will deliberately maintain more than one independent pathway for every data domain that is critical to its decision-making. Overlapping sources are not waste; they are the basis of verification, and they ensure that the loss or interruption of any single channel degrades the common operating picture rather than blinding it.

6.3 Fitness for purpose

Data and information systems should be designed around decisions and operational needs, not around technology for its own sake. Every data domain, information product and system component in this framework is justified by a specific decision or coordination function it supports. AfHA should resist the temptation to collect, store or process data whose decision relevance cannot be clearly articulated.

6.4 Minimum viable capability first

AfHA will establish the smallest credible information function needed to perform its coordination and decision-support roles, then expand over time as capacity, resources and institutional relationships

mature. This principle prevents three common institutional failures: building an overly ambitious architecture too early, duplicating systems already run by others, and creating information processes that depend on individuals rather than institutions.

6.5 Verified and tiered use

Not all information has equal status. AfHA will systematically distinguish between verified, partially verified and provisional information, and will apply tiered access and dissemination rules accordingly. Information that influences activation decisions or public communications must meet a higher verification standard than information used for internal situational awareness. This principle protects AfHA's credibility and the affected populations whose situations are being described.

6.6 Protection and responsibility

Sensitive data, especially personal, protection-related and security-sensitive data, must be handled with caution, necessity and clear access controls. AfHA applies the principle of minimum necessary collection: it will not gather personal or sensitive data beyond what is required for a defined and legitimate coordination or protection purpose. Data governance provisions for sensitive data are set out in detail in section 15.

6.7 Timeliness and traceability

Information should be timely enough to support the decision for which it is gathered, and traceable enough to support accountability after the decision is taken. Both dimensions are equally important: information that arrives accurately but too late has no operational value, and information that cannot be traced to its source has no accountability value. Every information product should record its sources, the date and time of production and the confidence level applied.

6.8 Open standards where possible

AfHA should promote common definitions, metadata schemas, geographic coding, event classification and exchange standards wherever feasible. The adoption of open standards reduces the cost of interoperability for all parties, strengthens the comparability of information across regions, and builds the continent's long-term information infrastructure rather than creating proprietary dependencies.

6.9 Multilevel usability

Information products should be useful and accessible across continental, regional and national levels, adapted to the different decision cycles, technical capacities and information needs of different users. A continental humanitarian watch note and a national incident brief serve different audiences with different information requirements. AfHA should design its products with the end user's decision in mind, not with institutional self-documentation as the primary purpose.

7. AfHA's data and information role

AfHA's role in humanitarian data and information is not to become the sole producer of all relevant data in Africa. Its role is to serve as a continental information integrator, analyst and coordination enabler.

This role has six dimensions, each of which supports AfHA's broader coordination mandate.

7.1 Information integration

AfHA receives and combines data and information from national systems, RECs, AU institutions and partners into shared situational products. Integration requires both technical interoperability and relational trust: data providers share with AfHA because they understand how their data will be used, who will access it and what products it will inform. AfHA should invest in these trust relationships as systematically as it invests in technical exchange routines.

7.2 Information validation support

AfHA applies transparent validation and confidence procedures so that users of its products understand what is confirmed, what is estimated and what is provisional. Validation is not the same as ground-truthing: AfHA will not always be able to verify information independently. What it can always do is assess the reliability of the source, the consistency of the data with other available evidence, and the appropriate confidence level for the specific decision at hand.

7.3 Decision support

AfHA produces concise and relevant products that support activation, coordination, prioritisation, anticipatory action, financing and strategic engagement. Decision support is the purpose of the information function, not an incidental output. The coordination pathways are governed by Framework 1, financing decisions by Framework 2, anticipatory action procedures by Framework 5, and advocacy clearance by Framework 6. This framework defines the information products, verification standards and timeliness requirements that support those decisions.

7.4 Information interoperability

AfHA promotes common structures, standards and exchange routines so that the information systems of Member States, RECs, AU institutions and partners can communicate with one another. This is both a technical function, maintaining data standards and exchange protocols, and a governance function, negotiating and maintaining the institutional agreements that permit data exchange.

7.5 Coordination visibility

AfHA tracks who is doing what, where and with what gaps at a level sufficient for its coordination role. Coordination visibility does not require comprehensive operational data: it requires enough information about response activities, resource flows and institutional positioning to allow AfHA to identify gaps, avoid overlap and support collective prioritisation.

7.6 Learning and system strengthening

AfHA uses its information practice to strengthen broader African capacities in data use, crisis reporting, common operating picture development and information governance. This framework defines the information standards, tools and review inputs required for that learning. The competency pathways, training delivery, simulations and deployable analytical support needed to sustain those capacities are governed by the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework.

8. Definition of AfHA's Minimum Viable Information Function

A defining characteristic of this framework is its explicit recognition that AfHA, as a new institution, cannot and should not attempt to build a fully-fledged continental information architecture from the outset. The Minimum Viable Information Function (MVIF) provides the discipline and realism needed to operate effectively from day one while laying the foundation for progressive expansion. This section defines what the MVIF is, what it comprises and why this approach is necessary.

8.1 Definition

It is not a full data platform. It is a disciplined initial capability, grounded in the principle of fitness for purpose, that enables AfHA to do the following:

- receive and log alerts, requests and updates
- maintain a basic common operating picture
- validate and synthesise key information from multiple sources
- support activation and coordination decisions
- produce routine and emergency information products
- communicate with Regional Centres, RECs, Member States and key partners
- preserve minimum records and auditability.

8.2 Components of the Minimum Viable Information Function

The MVIF consists of seven core components. These components are the minimum necessary set for AfHA to perform credible information and decision-support roles; they are not a ceiling on what AfHA will eventually build.

8.2.1 A headquarters information cell

A small unit at AfHA Headquarters, linked to the situation room, with the minimum staff and equipment necessary to run the continental humanitarian information function. During Phase 1, the cell shall operate during defined core hours while maintaining continuous out-of-hours reachability through a primary and alternate duty-officer arrangement. During heightened readiness or activation, the Information and Analysis Lead may move the cell to extended-hours or continuously staffed shifts. The cell performs the watch, intake, synthesis and dissemination functions central to AfHA's coordination role.

8.2.2 Defined focal point network

Named information focal points in Regional Centres, RECs and, where possible, Member States, each with defined reporting responsibilities, contact details and minimum reporting templates. The network is the nervous system of AfHA's information function; without named focal points and agreed routines, information flows depend on personal initiative rather than institutional design.

8.2.3 Common data intake and logging process

A single, documented process for receiving, logging, triaging and routing alerts, updates, requests and reports. All information that enters AfHA's systems should pass through this process, regardless of channel or format, so that the completeness and traceability of the information record can be maintained.

8.2.4 Minimum common operating picture

A basic but current view of major hazards, impacts, affected areas, population concerns, response status and key gaps, maintained in a format that can be updated and shared with relevant stakeholders within a defined time from receipt of new information. The common operating picture is AfHA's primary coordination visibility tool and the foundation of its situation reporting.

8.2.5 Standard information products

A limited number of recurring information products with agreed templates, production timelines and dissemination clearance procedures. Having a defined, predictable product suite is more valuable than producing occasional ad hoc documents: it builds institutional habit, sets partner expectations and creates a reviewable record of AfHA's information function over time.

8.2.6 Minimum technology stack

A practical set of hardware, software and connectivity tools sufficient for secure communication, data logging, geographic visualisation and basic analysis. The technology stack must be resilient and maintainable under AfHA's resource and capacity constraints, not optimised for a best-case scenario.

8.2.7 Basic governance rules

Simple, documented rules on information verification, sharing permissions, confidentiality, storage, retention and access. Governance rules do not need to be complex to be effective; they need to be clear, consistently applied and known to all staff.

8.3 Why a minimum viable model is necessary

The minimum viable approach prevents three common institutional failures:

- attempting to build an overly ambitious information architecture too early
- duplicating specialised systems already run by others
- relying on informal, personality-based information flows that cannot scale.

9. Minimum Viable Information Function: institutional architecture

The MVIF is operationalised through four inter-connected institutional layers: a Headquarters information cell, Regional information functions, national interfaces and a defined relationship with AU and continental systems. Each layer has distinct responsibilities and a defined relationship to the others. The design principle is that information flows up, down and horizontally through these layers with named focal points and expected timelines at every node.

9.1 Headquarters information cell

AfHA Headquarters shall establish a small Information and Analysis Cell within or closely linked to the situation room. For clarity of terminology across the foundational frameworks: the continental humanitarian coordination hub described in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework is the standing coordination function; the Information and Analysis Cell is the information staffing component of that hub; and the situation room is the physical and technical facility from which both operate. The three terms describe one integrated capability, not three separate structures.

This cell is the central node of AfHA's information function. During Phase 1, a 24-hour watch capability means that approved alert channels are continuously reachable and monitored through a documented duty and on-call arrangement; it does not necessarily mean that the situation room is physically staffed at all times. During heightened readiness or activation, AfHA shall introduce extended-hours or continuously staffed shifts when the risk, expected workload and available resources justify them.

In the first phase, the cell should ideally include at least the following roles:

- one Information and Analysis Lead
- one Humanitarian Information Management Officer
- one Data and Visualisation Officer
- one duty or support analyst, or cross-trained officer
- access to surge or standby analytical support where required.

The minimum duty arrangement shall identify a primary duty officer, an alternate duty officer and a senior escalation contact for every duty period. It shall include a duty roster, approved out-of-hours alert channels, acknowledgement and logging requirements, a shift-handover record, procedures for activating additional staff and a fallback arrangement when the primary duty officer or communication channel is unavailable.

The minimum responsibilities of the cell are to:

- maintain incident and information logs
- compile the common operating picture
- prepare analytical briefs and situation products
- support activation decisions
- liaise with Regional Centres and external systems
- maintain minimum information standards and templates.

9.2 Regional information functions

Regional Centres provide the geographic depth that the Headquarters cell cannot maintain for all regions simultaneously. Regional information functions should be deliberately light, avoiding the duplication of analytical capacity that properly belongs to RECs and national systems, while being sufficient to provide regional context, issue escalation and data validation support to Headquarters.

Each Regional Centre should have, at minimum, the following:

- one regional data and information focal point
- access to collocated or linked REC information systems where possible
- capacity to submit regional summaries, issue notes and cross-border updates.

Regional functions should be light, but sufficient to provide regional context, issue escalation and data validation support. Each Regional Centre should also be able to sustain a basic regional watch and reporting function autonomously for a defined period if communication with Headquarters is interrupted. Continuity of the information function must not depend on any single site remaining operational.

9.3 National interfaces

AfHA will not normally build independent national information systems. Instead, it works through designated national focal institutions and agreed contact points. This is consistent with the principle of member state data ownership and with the complementarity test in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework.

Of the national focal points designated under the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework, the following serve as AfHA's information interfaces:

- one national operational focal point
- one national information focal point where possible.

9.4 Relationship with AU and continental systems

AfHA's MVIF should be explicitly linked to existing continental systems, especially those relating to early warning, public health and displacement, through agreed information exchange arrangements and practical working routines.

The most important AU and continental system relationships for the MVIF are those with the continental multi-hazard early warning and advisory system, public health surveillance platforms, displacement and migration monitoring systems, and the Peace and Security Council's conflict early warning architecture. AfHA's information cell should have defined, regularised information exchange routines with each of these, specifying what information is exchanged, at what frequency, in what format and through which contact.

10. Minimum datasets and data domains

AfHA's initial information function should focus on a manageable set of data domains that are essential for coordination and decision support. These domains are not exhaustive; they are the minimum necessary set for AfHA to maintain a credible common operating picture, support activation decisions and produce its core information products. Each domain has defined minimum content. All data in these domains should carry a source tag, a date and time stamp and a confidence level.

An important cross-cutting requirement across all data domains is the application of sex, age and disability disaggregated data standards. Collecting undifferentiated aggregate figures for affected populations systematically obscures the differentiated needs of women, girls, children, older persons, persons with disabilities and other groups facing compounded vulnerability. AfHA should embed disaggregation requirements in its data intake templates, its information product standards and its partner reporting requirements from the outset, rather than treating disaggregated data as an optional addition. Where disaggregated data is not available, the information product should note its absence rather than presenting aggregate data as if it were complete.

10.1 Hazard and risk information

This domain provides the foundational situational picture on which all other domains depend. It should be sourced primarily from recognised national, regional and continental meteorological, hydrological, geological, epidemiological and food security monitoring systems rather than generated independently by AfHA.

Minimum content includes the following:

- type of hazard or crisis
- location and geographic extent
- severity or projected severity
- timing and likely evolution
- confidence or certainty level.

10.2 Early warning information

Early warning information is the most time-sensitive data domain and the one most directly linked to anticipatory action. AfHA's approach to this domain is to receive, synthesise and forward early warning products rather than to generate them. The primary source for continental multi-hazard early warning information is the Africa Multi-Hazard Early Warning and Early Action System (AMHEWAS); regional and national meteorological and climate centres provide the underlying data.

Minimum content includes the following:

- type of hazard
- location and geographic extent
- severity or projected severity
- timing and likely evolution
- impact-based forecast (projected humanitarian consequences)
- anticipatory action relevance flag.

10.3 Exposure and affected population information

Population exposure and impact data should include sex, age and disability disaggregation wherever available, and information products should explicitly flag when disaggregated data is unavailable.

Minimum content includes the following:

- estimated population exposed
- estimated affected population
- displaced or at-risk groups
- sex, age and disability breakdown where available
- vulnerable group flags.

10.4 Impact information

Impact data is often the most contested and most time-lagged element of the common operating picture. AfHA should clearly distinguish between field-verified impact data, partner-reported data and estimated or modelled impact. Remote sensing products, where available, can provide rapid initial impact estimates in contexts where ground access is constrained. Minimum content includes the following.

Minimum content includes the following:

- deaths and injuries where known
- infrastructure disruption
- service disruption
- livelihood and access impacts
- displacement or movement implications.

10.5 Response and coordination information

This domain underpins AfHA's coordination visibility function. The aim is not comprehensive response tracking but sufficient visibility to identify gaps, avoid duplication and support collective prioritisation. Minimum content includes the following.

Minimum content includes the following:

- affected Member State action
- REC action where relevant
- key partner engagement
- gaps requiring attention
- requests for support
- AfHA actions taken or pending.

10.6 Logistics and access information

Logistics and access information is critical in cross-border and remote-area crises where the primary operational constraint is the ability to move people and supplies rather than the availability of resources. AfHA should develop information exchange routines with border management, transport and logistics partners to maintain currency in this domain. Minimum content includes the following.

Minimum content includes the following:

- road, border and corridor status
- airport and seaport functionality
- warehousing or depot relevance
- movement constraints
- access limitations.

10.7 Anticipatory action trigger information

This domain is the information bridge between early warning, anticipatory action and financing. Framework 3 defines the trigger evidence, source confirmation, confidence level and information record required for activation decisions. The operational design of triggers, playbooks and pre-authorised actions is governed by the Preparedness, Anticipatory Action and Risk Reduction Framework, while the financing release pathway is governed by the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework. Minimum content is set out below.

Trigger information should include the following minimum elements:

- trigger indicator: the specific index or variable being monitored, with its source institution and the date and time of the reading
- threshold: the pre-agreed trigger level and whether it has been reached, exceeded or is approaching, with a confidence level
- area concerned: the precise geographic scope relevant to the pre-agreed anticipatory action playbook
- lead time: the estimated time between trigger confirmation and anticipated impact onset, determining which pre-authorised actions are feasible within the available window
- playbook reference: the approved playbook section to which the trigger condition relates, without redefining the action set in this framework
- decision pathway reference: the approved activation and financing pathway that will be used, as defined in the preparedness and financing frameworks
- source confirmation: confirmation from the designated early warning authority that the trigger condition has been met, distinct from AfHA's own assessment
- review record requirement: the information evidence that must be retained for the post-action review once the anticipated impact window has passed.

The trigger information for each anticipatory action scenario should be documented in a hazard-specific trigger information sheet prepared during the playbook development process governed by Framework 5. Framework 3 defines the information content and evidence standard for the sheet; Framework 5 governs playbook approval and activation logic; and Framework 2 governs the financing release pathway. Template trigger information sheets form part of the SOP for anticipatory trigger information and action notes. These domains should be reviewed over time, but they provide the initial minimum baseline.

10.8 Impact-based forecast information

Impact-based forecasting is the discipline of translating hazard probability forecasts into projections of likely humanitarian consequences, connecting meteorological or epidemiological uncertainty ranges to estimates of affected populations, displacement, service disruption and mortality risk. It is the most important information innovation linking early warning to anticipatory action, and it is the domain where AfHA's information function can add most value beyond simple data relay.

Impact-based forecast products answer a different question from standard early warning products. A standard early warning product asks: what is the probability and intensity of a given hazard event? An impact-based forecast asks: if that hazard event occurs at the projected intensity, what is the likely humanitarian consequence for specific population groups in specific locations? The second question is the one that decision-makers and financing authorities need answered before they can authorise anticipatory action.

AfHA's initial impact-based forecasting capacity should be built through partnerships with recognised climate and humanitarian impact modelling institutions rather than through internal model development. AfHA's role is to commission, contextualise and disseminate impact-based forecasts produced by technical partners, and to develop the analytical capacity over time to review, validate and communicate these products to decision-making audiences. The use of these forecasts in preparedness calendars, trigger thresholds and playbook activation is governed by the Preparedness, Anticipatory Action and Risk Reduction Framework. The minimum content of an impact-based forecast product includes the following:

- hazard probability distribution: the range of projected hazard intensities with associated probabilities, sourced from the relevant early warning authority
- exposure profile: the population, infrastructure and livelihood systems in the hazard footprint, disaggregated by sex, age and disability where data allows
- impact projection: the estimated range of humanitarian consequences at each probability level, including affected population, displacement, service disruption and mortality risk
- confidence level: the quality and reliability of the underlying data and models, with explicit uncertainty ranges
- lead time: the available window for anticipatory action at each probability threshold, linked to the trigger conditions in the relevant playbook
- recommended action threshold: the probability or impact level at which anticipatory action is recommended, consistent with pre-agreed criteria.

10.9 Conflict-related crisis information

Armed conflict drives the greater part of humanitarian need on the continent, and the information function must be able to support coordination in conflict-affected settings. AfHA's role in this domain is deliberately narrow. Minimum content includes the following:

- humanitarian access constraints and access incidents affecting coordination or delivery
- displacement movements and their drivers where conflict is the cause
- operational security context at the level needed for staff safety and coordination decisions
- affected population estimates in conflict-affected areas, with explicit confidence levels.

All information in this domain is handled under the heightened sensitivity provisions of section 15.5 and the SOP for protection and ethical use of humanitarian data. Equally important is what AfHA does not collect: it does not produce or hold analysis attributing responsibility to parties to a conflict, tactical or military intelligence, or information concerning individual perpetrators or victims. These exclusions protect the perception of neutrality, independence and impartiality on which humanitarian access depends, and they keep AfHA's information function clearly separate from the conflict early warning architecture of the Peace and Security Council, with which it maintains a defined exchange interface only.

11. Core information products

AfHA's information credibility will be built primarily through its information products. A small number of standard products, produced to known formats and on predictable schedules, are more valuable than a large and inconsistent body of ad hoc outputs. The framework adopts a graduated, tiered product architecture inspired by the practice of mature regional coordination mechanisms: short, fast-moving initial products for rapid situational awareness; structured regular products for sustained situational tracking; and periodic analytical products for strategic learning and seasonal planning.

In the first phase, AfHA's product suite is divided into two tracks. The protected core consists of the continental humanitarian watch note, the incident brief and the situation report, together with the cross-border issue note produced as needed and the monthly information performance note. These carry an unconditional reliability commitment: they are produced on schedule, to standard, under all conditions, and their delivery takes precedence over all other information work. The second track consists of pilot products: the anticipatory action trigger note, initially for one approved playbook; impact-based forecast products, initially for one hazard in one geographic area; and the seasonal humanitarian outlook, initially produced with one REC. Pilot products are deliberately small, their cost and scope are capped, and each is promoted into the protected core only when a structured review confirms that it has been produced reliably and used in real decisions. Each product has a defined purpose, frequency, format and dissemination audience. Detailed templates and clearance procedures sit in the SOP for information products and dissemination clearance.

11.1 Continental humanitarian watch note

The continental humanitarian watch note is AfHA's primary routine situational awareness product. It provides a short, structured summary of major humanitarian risks, developments, trends and monitoring priorities across the continent. It is the minimum evidence that AfHA is fulfilling its continental monitoring role and the product most likely to be read by AU Member States, REC counterparts and partners who are not themselves in crisis.

11.2 Incident brief

An incident brief is produced for any new or significantly escalating humanitarian event to support an initial activation or heightened readiness decision. It translates early information about an emerging situation into the structured format needed by the Secretariat to make a timely and defensible decision about AfHA's initial response. Its quality and speed determine whether AfHA's activation decisions are made on evidence or on impression.

11.3 Situation report

The situation report is AfHA's primary product during an active emergency. It provides a structured, time-stamped summary of impacts, actions, needs, gaps and issues, and it serves as the primary information tool for both internal coordination and external communication during a response. Situation reports should maintain consistent format across events so that readers can locate key information quickly without reorienting to a new structure for each emergency.

11.4 Cross-border issue note

The cross-border issue note is a targeted product for transboundary risks, displacement flows, logistics constraints or coordination issues spanning more than one Member State or REC boundary. It is the product category that most directly expresses AfHA's continental added value: situations that no single REC or Member State can address in full and that require continental visibility and facilitation. Cross-border issue notes may be distributed to a more limited audience than continental watch notes, reflecting the diplomatic sensitivity of some cross-border situations.

Product	Frequency	Typical length	Primary audience	Clearance
Continental humanitarian watch note	Weekly in routine; daily if required	1-2 pages	AfHA leadership, RECs, AU	Information Analysis Lead and

Product	Frequency	Typical length	Primary audience	Clearance
			counterparts, selected partners	
Incident brief	As needed, within 4 hours of confirmed new event	1 page	Secretariat, Operations Lead, relevant Regional Centre	Secretariat
Situation report	Daily during activation; less frequent in tail phases	2-4 pages	Internal teams, AU channels, RECs, Member States, approved partners	Secretariat or delegated authority
Cross-border issue note	As needed	1-2 pages	Regional Centres, RECs, concerned Member States, Headquarters	Information Analysis Lead and
Anticipatory action trigger note	As needed, linked to trigger monitoring cycle; pilot: one playbook initially	1-2 pages plus trigger information sheet	Secretariat, Operations, Finance, relevant Regional Centre, technical partners	Secretariat
Impact-based forecast assessment	As required and aligned with the relevant forecast cycle; pilot: one hazard and one geographic area initially	2-4 pages, with a technical annex where required	Executive Secretary, Operations Lead, relevant Regional Centre or REC, and approved technical partners	Executive Secretary or delegated authority
Monthly information performance note	Monthly	1-2 pages	Headquarters management and information leadership	Information Analysis Lead and
Seasonal humanitarian outlook	Twice yearly, aligned to the continental climate forecast calendar (pilot: one REC initially)	3-5 pages	AfHA leadership, participating REC, Member State preparedness focal points, AU planning Cycle	Secretariat

11.5 Anticipatory action trigger note

The anticipatory action trigger note warrants additional detail given its critical role in connecting AfHA's information and financing functions. The note should include all elements of the trigger information domain described in section 10.7, presented in a standardised format that allows the Secretariat or designated authority to make an activation decision without searching for information across multiple documents. The note should include the following sections:

- trigger status: clear statement of whether the trigger threshold has been met, exceeded or not yet reached, with the source institution's confirmation
- lead time assessment: the estimated time available for anticipatory action and which playbook actions are feasible within that window

- impact-based forecast summary: a brief synthesis of the projected humanitarian consequences if no anticipatory action is taken, with confidence level
- playbook action reference: the specific pre-authorised action set in the approved playbook to which the trigger condition relates
- financial pathway reference: the budget ceiling and approval pathway defined under the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework
- decision required: a clear, single-sentence statement of what the Secretariat is being asked to decide
- dissemination clearance: confirmation of who will receive the note and in what form.

A blank trigger note template, with instructions for each section, is part of the SOP for anticipatory trigger information and action notes. AfHA should prepare completed draft trigger note templates for each approved anticipatory action playbook during the playbook development process, so that the information-gathering and formatting work is completed in advance rather than under time pressure at activation.

11.6 Monthly information performance note

The monthly information performance note is an internal management and learning product. It provides a short review of information flows, product timeliness, data gaps and system issues over the preceding month, and it serves as the primary mechanism through which the information function improves over time. Its most important content is the record of errors and near-misses: alerts missed or nearly missed, products issued late, confidence grades that later proved wrong, and flows that failed. These are recorded without attribution of blame; their purpose is corrective, and each entry is treated as direct evidence of where templates, routines or training need to change. A performance note that reports only successes indicates a failure of the review process itself. The note should be read by Headquarters management and information leadership and should feed into the annual reporting on AfHA's performance indicators.

11.7 Seasonal humanitarian outlook

The seasonal humanitarian outlook enters the suite as a pilot product from the first phase, produced with one REC for one climate forecast cycle, and expands toward continental coverage as the pilot demonstrates reliability and decision value. During the pilot, distribution may be limited to the participating REC and internal leadership. A seasonal outlook draws on seasonal forecast information from continental and regional climate centres and projects its likely humanitarian implications for the coming season across different hazard types and geographic areas. It provides the evidence base for preparedness planning, anticipatory action, pre-positioning decisions and resource mobilisation, while the operational use of the outlook is governed by Frameworks 2, 4 and 5.

A seasonal outlook is not a prediction: it is a probability-weighted assessment of humanitarian risk conditions over the coming season, clearly communicated with uncertainty ranges and confidence levels. Once promoted into the protected core, it should be produced at least twice a year, aligned with the continental climate forecast calendar, and distributed to AfHA leadership, RECs, member state preparedness focal points and the AU planning cycle. The seasonal outlook is the information product most likely to generate early political attention and resourcing for anticipated crises, and AfHA should invest in its quality and communication value accordingly.

12. Information flow model

AfHA should organise information flow through a simple but disciplined model with four defined directions. Each flow direction has named focal points, expected timelines and preferred channels. Defining these flows in advance, rather than allowing them to emerge informally, is what distinguishes a reliable information function from a personality-dependent one.

12.1 Upward flow

Upward flow carries information from Member States, humanitarian partners and Regional Centres to AfHA Headquarters for synthesis, validation and escalation. This is the primary data-gathering flow that feeds the common operating picture and informs activation decisions. Upward flow should follow defined reporting templates and submission timelines, so that Headquarters knows what to expect, when and from whom. Where a regular submission is missing or significantly delayed, the information cell should follow up proactively rather than waiting for information to arrive spontaneously.

Upward flow is sustained by reciprocity, not obligation. Every institution that reports into AfHA's systems must receive demonstrable value in return within weeks of contributing, not years: priority access to AfHA's products, visible attribution of its contribution, and analytical support from the information cell during its own crises. The information function should treat the question of what the contributor received in return as a standing design test for every reporting routine it establishes.

12.2 Downward flow

Downward flow carries strategic and operational products from Headquarters to Regional Centres, AU structures and approved partners. It includes the dissemination of information products, activation notices, updated common operating pictures and guidance on information priorities. Downward flow should be structured so that Regional Centres receive what they need to perform their regional information function, not simply a copy of every product produced at Headquarters.

12.3 Horizontal flow

Horizontal flow supports the exchange of information between Regional Centres, between RECs and Member States, and across technical functions within AfHA. Facilitating horizontal flow, between institutions at the same level of the system, is one of AfHA's most distinctive and valuable coordination contributions: it enables cross-border coordination, peer learning and mutual situational awareness between regional actors who may otherwise lack formal information exchange routines.

12.4 Triggered flow

Triggered flow is information that moves automatically or procedurally when defined thresholds, activation levels or major incidents occur. Unlike routine flows, triggered flow is designed to be fast, targeted and difficult to miss. Examples of triggered flow include the automatic notification of designated contacts when a trigger threshold is approached, the distribution of an incident brief within a defined time of a confirmed new event, and the initiation of a common operating picture update cycle when an emergency is declared. Triggered flow rules should be documented in advance and tested through simulation exercises so that they function correctly under crisis conditions rather than only in theory.

All flows should have named focal points, expected timelines and preferred channels.

13. Interoperability model

Interoperability is AfHA's primary information strategy: linking and harmonising existing systems rather than duplicating them. AfHA will pursue interoperability at four levels, recognising that each level requires different investments and different timelines, and that progress at higher levels depends on the foundations laid at lower levels.

13.1 Institutional interoperability

Institutional interoperability is the foundation of the model and the most immediately achievable level. It consists of agreed relationships, named focal points, memoranda of understanding and working arrangements that establish the basis for data and information exchange between institutions. Institutional interoperability does not require technology alignment: it requires mutual understanding of roles, responsibilities and exchange terms. AfHA should prioritise establishing institutional interoperability arrangements with its most important information partners, starting with the

continental early warning system, Africa CDC, regional meteorological and climate centres, and the displacement and migration monitoring system, in the first phase of operation.

13.2 Semantic interoperability

Semantic interoperability means that institutions use the same definitions, event categories, geographic coding systems, date and time conventions, and metadata standards, so that data shared by one institution can be understood and used by another without manual translation. This is an area where AfHA can play a genuine standard-setting role, convening technical working groups to agree on common terminology and classification systems for African humanitarian data and advocating for their adoption by Member States, RECs and partners. Open international standards, including established geographic coding systems, humanitarian event taxonomies and population data categories, should be adopted wherever they fit the African context rather than duplicated with African-specific variants.

The controlled list of applicable standards is maintained in Annex A: Humanitarian Data Interoperability Standards Register. The register identifies mandatory AU standards, AfHA-adopted open standards, controlled vocabularies, code lists, exchange formats and mappings to partner standards. It shall be reviewed at least annually and whenever a relevant AU standard or source system materially changes. Where no applicable AU standard has been formally prescribed, AfHA may adopt an open standard as an interim institutional default, clearly recording its authority and status in the register.

13.3 Technical interoperability

Technical interoperability involves agreed data formats, exchange files, application programming interfaces and other mechanisms that allow systems to exchange data with minimal manual intervention. This level requires the most investment and the most coordination, and it is appropriate primarily for information flows that are high-volume, high-frequency and well-established. AfHA should pursue technical interoperability selectively, beginning with the data exchanges that are most operationally critical and most mature in their institutional relationship. Remote sensing and satellite data, where available and authorised, can provide technically interoperable rapid impact assessment products that complement slower ground-based reporting.

13.4 Operational interoperability

Operational interoperability means that institutions share not just data but routines: common product calendars, shared trigger and activation cycles, and coordinated decision-making processes that allow information exchange to support joint action rather than parallel action. This is the level of interoperability that enables anticipatory action coordination, where AfHA's trigger monitoring cycle is synchronised with the early warning institution's forecast production cycle, the preparedness playbook cycle and the financing authority's approval timeline. Framework 3 defines the information exchange routines; Frameworks 4 and 5 govern the simulation, readiness and operational testing processes through which those routines are validated.

AfHA should begin with institutional and semantic interoperability, then progressively expand into technical and operational interoperability.

13.5 Interoperability with AMHEWAS

The single most important interoperability relationship in this framework is the one between AfHA and AMHEWAS. As established in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework, AfHA does not generate early warning data; it receives, synthesises and translates early warning outputs into humanitarian action. The quality of this translation depends entirely on the quality of the information exchange between the two institutions.

AfHA should develop a formal information exchange protocol with the continental early warning system that specifies the following:

- which specific products and data outputs AfHA will receive, and on what schedule

- the format and transmission mechanism for routine and triggered information
- the procedure for rapid consultation when a trigger threshold is being approached and the lead time for confirmation is short
- the role of the early warning authority in confirming trigger conditions for anticipatory action financing activation
- the format and content of the impact-based forecast products that the early warning authority will produce or support
- the post-action review obligations, including how early warning performance will be assessed alongside humanitarian response performance
- the procedure for mutual notification when either institution's monitoring or production capability is interrupted, and the arrangements that apply until it is restored.

The formal AMHEWAS information-exchange protocol shall be negotiated, approved and signed no later than the end of AfHA's first operational year.

The importance of this relationship must not make it a single point of failure. Where AMHEWAS products are unavailable, delayed or incomplete, the information cell draws directly on regional climate centres, national meteorological and hydrological services and assessed open sources, under the same validation and confidence-grading discipline. In these conditions the common operating picture degrades gracefully; it does not go dark.

14. Minimum technology stack

AfHA's technology environment in its first phase should be governed by the same minimum viable principle that shapes its information function. A lean, resilient and maintainable technology stack, chosen for the conditions AfHA will actually work in rather than for the conditions of a best-resourced scenario, is more valuable than a sophisticated platform that depends on connectivity, bandwidth or technical expertise that AfHA does not yet possess. Technology should enable the information function, not drive it.

The minimum technology stack should include the following components:

- secure laptops and desktops
- shared cloud or server storage with controlled access
- incident and request logging tool
- standard spreadsheet and database capability
- GIS and basic visualisation software
- secure communication tools
- display screens or wallboard for the situation room
- backup power and connectivity where possible
- document templates and version control.

Over time this can evolve into a more integrated humanitarian information platform. In selecting specific tools within each category, AfHA should apply the following criteria: the tool must be available and licensed for use within the AU institutional environment; it must be maintainable by AfHA's own staff without specialist contractor support for routine operation; it must be resilient against the connectivity and power supply constraints that characterise many AfHA deployment contexts; and it must be compatible with the technical interoperability standards adopted in section 13. Proprietary tools that create long-term vendor dependency or that cannot be transferred to successor staff should be avoided where open or standard alternatives are available.

Every tool in the stack must also have a documented low-technology fallback: the procedure by which its function is performed by telephone, paper or standalone file if the tool, its connectivity or its power supply fails. Fallback procedures are tested in the same exercises that test the tools themselves. The measure of the technology stack is not its sophistication in favourable conditions but the continuity of the information function in unfavourable ones.

15. Data governance

Robust data governance is the institutional foundation of AfHA's information credibility. Partners and Member States will only share sensitive or time-critical information with AfHA if they are confident that it will be used responsibly, stored securely, attributed correctly and shared only within agreed parameters. Data governance rules should be simple enough to be followed consistently, specific enough to be enforceable and visible enough to be trusted. This section sets out AfHA's data governance requirements across five dimensions.

15.1 Data classification

AfHA should classify all information at one of four levels:

- public
- internal
- restricted
- confidential.

The classification determines storage location, access permissions and dissemination rules. All incoming information should be assigned a classification on receipt. If the source institution has specified a handling caveat, that caveat takes precedence over AfHA's default classification for the same data type. Classification should be reviewed when information is included in a product that will be disseminated to a broader audience than the original receipt.

15.2 Verification status

AfHA should mark all information products with a confidence level, using a simple standard scale. The scale should distinguish at minimum between the following levels:

- verified
- partially verified
- provisional
- unverified.

No product should imply precision or certainty beyond what the underlying data supports. Where information at a higher confidence level is unavailable, AfHA's job is to say so clearly and provide a best available estimate with an appropriate caveat, rather than to remain silent or to present low-confidence data without flagging its limitations.

15.3 Access control

Not all users require access to all data. Access should be role-based and proportionate to the specific information needs of each role. A regional coordinator needs access to regional situation data but not necessarily to sensitive national data received under restricted terms. A finance officer needs access to trigger confirmation records but not necessarily to all operational coordination data. Role-based access controls should be implemented from the outset and reviewed when roles change.

15.4 Retention and records

All AfHA records, regardless of format, shall be managed in accordance with the AU Archives and Records Management Policy and the current AU Retention and Disposal Schedule and Procedure.

The designated AfHA administrative or records-management function shall liaise with the competent AU records authority and the AU Archivist to map each AfHA record series to the applicable AU retention requirement and final disposition action. Where an AfHA record series is not covered by the current AU schedule, it shall be referred to the competent AU records authority before a retention period or disposition action is assigned.

No official AfHA record shall be destroyed, erased, deleted, returned to a source or otherwise disposed of without:

- expiry of the approved retention period;
- confirmation that no legal, audit, investigation, operational, historical, source-imposed or partner hold applies;
- archival appraisal where the record may have enduring value;
- the written authorisation required under AU policy; and
- recording of the completed disposition action.

Records identified as having archival or historical value shall be transferred to the AU Archives or other approved institutional archive.

Personal and sensitive data shall be retained only for as long as necessary for the legitimate purpose for which they were collected or processed. Where data-protection requirements, source conditions or partner agreements conflict with a records-retention requirement, no disposal or continued retention decision shall be made until the matter has been referred to the competent legal, data-protection and records-management authorities.

The Governing Board or Secretariat may direct longer preservation where required for institutional accountability, but shall not shorten an AU retention period or authorise disposal outside the applicable AU procedure.

15.5 Sensitive data

Personal, protection-related, security-sensitive and politically sensitive data should be collected and shared only when necessary and under stricter controls than standard information. This category includes data about specific individuals in displacement or protection situations, information about security conditions that could compromise ongoing operations or personnel, and data whose premature release could damage diplomatic relationships or operational access. AfHA should develop a sensitive data handling policy, implemented through the SOP for protection and ethical use of humanitarian data, that defines what constitutes sensitive data, who may authorise its collection, how it may be used and under what circumstances it may be shared outside AfHA.

16. Quality assurance

AfHA's information credibility will depend heavily on the quality assurance discipline applied to its products and processes. Quality assurance is not a separate audit function; it is a set of habits embedded in daily information work. The following minimum quality control steps should be applied to all information products:

- source recording
- date and time stamping
- version control
- cross-checking where feasible
- peer review of key products
- use of standard templates
- explicit flagging of uncertainty.

Quality assurance performance should be reviewed monthly through the information performance note described in section 11.6, and product quality concerns should be escalated to the Information and Analysis Lead for resolution.

Quality assurance also includes calibration: tracking whether assigned confidence levels proved accurate once events unfolded. The information cell maintains a simple running record, by product line, of how often material graded as verified was subsequently contradicted and how often provisional estimates proved sound. This record is reviewed monthly alongside the information

performance note. Consistent and honest grading of uncertainty is a condition for wider dissemination authority; systematic overconfidence is treated as a quality failure even where individual products appear polished. In addition, the trigger information chain, the intake process and the common operating picture update cycle are tested through periodic unannounced exercises, coordinated with the simulation programme governed by the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework, so that failure is first experienced under practice conditions rather than in a live crisis. After each major activation, a structured review of information product quality, timeliness and utility should be conducted and its findings incorporated into improvements to templates, processes and training.

17. Information support to activation and coordination

The practical value of AfHA's information function is tested most directly in its ability to support four decision areas: activation decisions, coordination activities, resource requests and anticipatory action decisions. The MVIF must be designed and resourced to support these areas simultaneously during a major emergency, not sequentially. Framework 3 provides the evidence base; the companion frameworks govern the operational decisions that use that evidence.

17.1 Activation support

AfHA's information function must be able to provide, within a defined time from the emergence of a potential crisis, sufficient verified information to support a defensible activation, non-activation or heightened-readiness decision by the Secretariat. The incident brief described in section 11.2 is the primary product for this purpose. Activation support requires the information cell to be able to receive and triage alerts at any hour, to initiate rapid information gathering from the focal point network, and to produce an initial brief within the timeline specified in the activation SOP. The information function is directly linked to the emergency financing procedures in the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework: the incident brief is often the first document in the activation and financing chain.

17.2 Coordination support

During an active emergency, the information function provides the common operating picture and issue tracking that sustains multi-level coordination. This requires the information cell to shift from routine monitoring mode to active production mode, increasing the frequency and specificity of its outputs and maintaining a live common operating picture that is accessible to all relevant coordination participants. The situation report series described in section 11.3 is the primary product for this purpose. Coordination support also requires the information cell to track requests for assistance, partner engagement and emerging gaps, so that the Secretariat and coordination structures have a continuously updated picture of what is happening, who is doing it and what remains unaddressed.

17.3 Resource support

The information function provides the evidence base for resource requests, whether for emergency financing drawdowns, surge deployment, logistics support or anticipatory action activation. Framework 3 defines the evidence packages and information standards required to justify those requests. Framework 2 governs financing release and accountability, while Framework 4 governs surge deployment and related readiness procedures. AfHA's information cell should develop standardised evidence packages for different types of resource request, drawing on the minimum dataset domains in section 10, so that the information needed to justify a resource decision is gathered systematically rather than assembled under pressure at the moment of request.

17.4 Information support to anticipatory action

Supporting anticipatory action is a qualitatively different information task from supporting emergency response. In emergency response, the information function is mainly retrospective: describing what

has happened. In anticipatory action, the information function is mainly prospective: assessing what is likely to happen within the available lead time and whether the information conditions for pre-authorised action have been met. Framework 3 governs the trigger evidence and information record. Framework 5 governs trigger thresholds, playbooks, activation procedures and post-action learning. Framework 2 governs the related financing release pathway.

Information support to anticipatory action involves the following specific functions:

- monitoring trigger indicators continuously during periods of elevated hazard probability, in close coordination with the continental early warning system
- producing impact-based forecast assessments as described in section 10.8, translating hazard probability into projected humanitarian consequence
- preparing or updating the trigger information sheet for active scenarios, maintaining its currency as forecast probabilities evolve
- producing the anticipatory action trigger note as described in section 11.5 when a trigger threshold is met or exceeded, within the timeline required by the relevant playbook
- supporting the post-action review by providing the information record of the trigger confirmation process, the actions taken and their humanitarian outcomes against the pre-crisis baseline
- contributing to seasonal outlook products that allow anticipatory action scenarios to be identified and playbooks to be developed during routine periods rather than reactively as hazard conditions develop.

18. Relationship with partners and external systems

Priority external information exchange relationships should include:

- Member State disaster and humanitarian focal institutions
- RECs and Regional Mechanisms
- AU early warning and crisis monitoring systems
- Africa CDC
- meteorological and climate centres
- displacement and migration systems
- humanitarian coordination partners
- selected global systems where useful.

AfHA should prioritise formal, repeated and useful exchange over broad but shallow information collection. The partnership arrangements themselves are governed by Framework 1; this framework defines the information exchange terms, formats, standards and governance requirements attached to those arrangements.

For each priority partner, AfHA should define: what information AfHA will provide to the partner; what information the partner will provide to AfHA; at what frequency; through which channel; under what sharing terms; and with which contact persons. These terms should be documented in a formal exchange arrangement and reviewed annually. AfHA should invest in being a useful partner, not only a demanding one: the quality and relevance of what AfHA provides will determine what partners are willing to share in return.

19. Phased development roadmap

AfHA's information function develops through three phases, each building on the foundation of the previous one. The phase structure is not defined primarily by timelines but by the achievement of defined capability milestones. The transition from one phase to the next should be confirmed through a structured review of information function performance rather than assumed on the basis of elapsed time.

Phase reviews look in both directions. They assess readiness to expand, and they equally assess what should be retired: any product, dataset or system component that cannot demonstrate use in real decisions since the last review is discontinued or redesigned. The information function remains minimal not because it never grows, but because it prunes as deliberately as it expands.

Phase 1: Minimum Viable Information Function

The first phase establishes the core information architecture described in this framework. Success is measured not by the sophistication of the technology but by the reliability and usefulness of the information products and processes AfHA delivers. The following priorities drive this phase:

- establish Headquarters information cell
- define focal point network
- create basic intake and logging process
- adopt standard templates
- produce the protected core products reliably and launch the capped pilot products
- create initial common operating picture
- define simple data governance rules.

Phase 2: Regional integration and stronger interoperability

The second phase deepens AfHA's regional reach and progressively moves toward technical and operational interoperability with key partners. The transition to Phase 2 should be triggered by the successful completion of the Phase 1 MVIF review and the availability of the Regional Centre information functions needed to support regional integration. The following priorities drive this phase:

- strengthen Regional Centre information functions
- improve data exchange routines with RECs and Member States
- standardise regional reporting and issue notes
- introduce more structured dashboards and analysis
- support anticipatory action information flows
- improve cross-border information products.

Phase 3: Mature continental interoperability

The third phase completes the transition from a minimum viable function to a mature, technically integrated continental information system. It is achieved progressively as technical interoperability arrangements are negotiated, tested and refined, and as AfHA's information team develops the analytical depth and institutional relationships needed to sustain a recognised continental humanitarian information role. The following priorities drive this phase:

- deepen technical interoperability
- refine system automation and data exchange
- support integrated forecasting and trigger systems
- strengthen learning and analytics
- maintain a recognised continental humanitarian information role.

20. Roles and responsibilities

The following table summarises the information-related roles and responsibilities across AfHA's leadership and staff. Detailed role definitions sit in AfHA's human resources framework; this table captures the minimum information-specific responsibilities relevant to this framework.

Table 1: Key information responsibilities

Role	Key information responsibilities
Secretariat	Strategic oversight of information function; approval of high-sensitivity dissemination decisions; authorisation of anticipatory action trigger notes and activation decisions; approval of major information policies
Information and Analysis Lead	Leadership of the MVIF; quality assurance across all products; development and maintenance of information standards and templates; interoperability development; oversight of trigger monitoring and anticipatory trigger notes; monthly information performance review
Situation Room Lead	Live monitoring, incident logging and common operating picture management; first-line alert triage; duty watch function; situation product support during activations
Regional Coordinators	Ensuring regional information flows are functioning; validating regional data before upward submission; escalating regional issues to Headquarters
Regional information focal points	Preparing regional summaries, cross-border issue notes and data coordination; maintaining regional focal point network relationships
Operations Lead	Ensuring information outputs support activation and coordination decisions; linking information function to operational and surge readiness processes
Finance and logistics leads	Providing and receiving operational information relevant to resource requests, logistics tracking and trigger confirmation documentation
Partnerships and external relations	Supporting external dissemination; managing partner information exchange arrangements; maintaining the external focal point directory

21. Risks and mitigation

The following table summarises the principal risks to AfHA's information function and the mitigation measures AfHA will apply. The risk register should be reviewed annually and updated to reflect evolving operational conditions.

Table 2: Risks and mitigation

Risk	Mitigation
Attempting to build too much too early	Adhere strictly to the Minimum Viable Information Function in Phase 1; gate transition to Phase 2 on MVIF performance review rather than elapsed time; resist technology investment proposals that are not linked to a defined operational need
Duplication with existing information systems	Map existing systems before building new tools; prioritise interoperability arrangements over new platforms; apply the complementarity test to every proposed information system investment

Risk	Mitigation
Poor data quality undermining credibility	Apply source tagging, verification rules and confidence labelling to all products; produce no product that implies false precision; invest in quality assurance habits early rather than correcting quality failures after trust has been damaged
Political sensitivity over data use and attribution	Respect national data ownership principles; apply tiered access rules; obtain sharing consent for sensitive national data; attribute sources appropriately in all products
Information overload reducing decision utility	Limit the initial suite to the protected core and capped pilot products in section 11; design products around specific decisions and named audiences; apply strict length and format discipline to all templates.
Understaffed information function	Define minimum staffing requirements and protect them in Phase 1 budget planning; develop surge analytical support arrangements; invest in cross-training so that information cell functions can be maintained during staff absence
Trigger information failure leading to anticipatory action delay	Develop trigger information sheets for all approved playbooks in advance; establish direct information exchange protocol with the early warning authority; test the trigger information chain through simulation exercises before first operational use
Sensitive data breach damaging institutional trust	Implement role-based access controls from inception; apply the sensitive data handling policy consistently; include data protection provisions in all partner exchange agreements
Interruption of a critical external input source, including AMHEWAS	Maintain at least two independent pathways for every critical data domain; document fallback sourcing procedures; include mutual outage notification in exchange protocols; test degraded-mode operation in periodic exercises.

22. Performance indicators

The following indicators provide a minimum framework for assessing the performance of AfHA's information function. They should be tracked monthly through the information performance note, reviewed semi-annually through the governance reporting cycle and refined annually based on operational experience. Additional context-specific indicators may be added as AfHA's systems mature. Indicative indicators include:

- number of functioning information focal points across regions
- percentage of incident briefs produced within target time
- percentage of situation products issued on schedule
- number of active information exchange arrangements with RECs and Member States
- percentage of products with source and confidence tagging
- time from trigger receipt to initial information brief
- user satisfaction with core products
- proportion of major activations supported by a common operating picture
- time from trigger threshold confirmation to completion of anticipatory action trigger note, measured against the lead time available in the relevant playbook
- proportion of information products carrying source attribution, date and time stamp and confidence level
- number of approved anticipatory action playbooks for which a completed trigger information sheet exists, as an information readiness indicator aligned to Framework 5

- proportion of major activations for which the information record required for post-action review was completed within the required timeframe
- number of formal information exchange arrangements in place with priority external partners, RECs and Member States
- proportion of major incidents for which a seasonal humanitarian outlook had identified an elevated risk in the relevant area and hazard type
- proportion of regularly contributing institutions that received priority products, attribution or analytical support within the reporting period
- proportion of information graded as verified that was subsequently contradicted, tracked by product line
- number of critical data domains with at least two independent, tested source pathways
- percentage of technology stack components with a documented and tested low-technology fallback procedure.

23. Implementation roadmap

The implementation roadmap below follows the same managed-ambition sequence as the preceding frameworks. AfHA first establishes the personnel, governance and basic tools of the information function, then launches its product suite and expands its partner exchange routines, then completes the first review and plans the transition to Phase 2 regional integration.

Within 3 months of adoption

Priority actions in this window are:

- define minimum staffing and roles
- approve data classification rules
- create initial templates and logs
- establish initial focal point directory
- identify basic technology requirements.

Within 6 months

Priority actions in this window are:

- operationalise Headquarters information cell
- launch weekly watch note
- test incident brief and sitrep production
- establish pilot exchange routines with selected Regional Centres and RECs
- issue first information governance guidance note.

Within 12 months

Priority actions in this window are:

- complete the first structured MVIF performance review and agree any required corrective actions
- refine products and workflows
- expand regional information focal point network
- align information function with activation and draw-down mechanisms
- negotiate, approve and sign the formal AMHEWAS information-exchange protocol, and test its primary and fallback communication channels
- prepare phased plan for Phase 2 interoperability.

Within 24 months of adoption, AfHA should additionally: complete a second structured MVIF performance review and, if the capability milestones in section 19 have been met, confirm readiness to transition to Phase 2; complete the first annual review and operational test of the formal AMHEWAS information-exchange protocol established during the first operational year; develop and approve the first anticipatory action trigger information sheets aligned with approved playbooks;

launch the seasonal humanitarian outlook product; and prepare the phased plan for regional integration of information functions.

24. Relationship with SOPs to be developed

This framework should be operationalised through a suite of linked standard operating procedures. Each SOP translates the procedural provisions of the framework into step-by-step operational guidance for AfHA staff, partners and focal points. The SOPs below should be aligned with the coordination SOPs under Framework 1, financing SOPs under Framework 2, surge and simulation SOPs under Framework 4, anticipatory action SOPs under Framework 5, and advocacy clearance arrangements under Framework 6.

The SOPs below are a target inventory, not a drafting programme to be completed speculatively. Three have been developed to date: the SOP for data collection, validation and sharing using AU standards, which also covers alert intake, logging and validation; the SOP for coordination with AMHEWAS, Africa CDC and RECs, which implements exchange protocol management with priority partners; and the SOP for protection and ethical use of humanitarian data, which covers sensitive data handling and access control. The remaining SOPs are drafted in minimal form only when the first phase of operations actually exercises the procedures they describe, and every SOP is revised on the basis of after-action review rather than anticipated need. Procedures earn their permanence through use. The following SOPs are required:

- SOP for data collection and sharing
- SOP for humanitarian data interoperability standards
- SOP for coordination with AMHEWAS, Africa CDC, and RECs
- SOP for protection and ethical use of humanitarian data.

25. Conclusion

The Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework provides the information architecture that AfHA will need to become a credible, coordinated and evidence-based continental humanitarian institution. By defining both a long-term interoperability vision and a realistic MVIF, it allows AfHA to begin with discipline and clarity rather than waiting for a perfect system that never comes. If implemented well, this framework will enable AfHA to connect warning to action, coordination to evidence, and African humanitarian leadership to a trusted and usable information foundation.

The framework reflects four design commitments that go beyond what most new continental institutions have articulated explicitly at the start of their information journey. First, that the information function is not a support service sitting behind operational activity but a core operational capability that enables everything else AfHA does: without credible, timely and decision-relevant information, there is no activation, no coordination and no anticipatory action. Second, that impact-based forecasting, connecting hazard probability to humanitarian consequence, is the information discipline most likely to save lives at scale, and AfHA must invest in it systematically rather than treating it as an advanced-stage aspiration. Third, that sex, age and disability disaggregated data standards must be embedded in templates, intake processes and product requirements from day one, not added later when the cost of retrofitting is high and the data gaps are already established. Fourth, that the information exchange relationship with AMHEWAS is not one relationship among many but the single most important interoperability priority in the entire framework, and it must be formalised, tested and maintained with the same care that AfHA invests in its most important financing and coordination relationships.

Implementation will be phased and evidence-led. The MVIF is not a limitation on AfHA's ambition; it is the responsible starting point from which that ambition can be realised. A small, disciplined and well-governed information function that delivers reliable products on time builds the institutional

credibility and partner trust that attracts the investment needed to expand. Conversely, an overambitious information architecture that cannot be maintained or that produces inconsistent, unreliable products will damage AfHA's credibility precisely when it needs it most. The discipline of starting small and building well is the information framework's most important strategic choice.

Delivered with the same managed ambition that governs the financing and coordination frameworks, the information function described in this framework has the potential to become one of AfHA's most visible and most valued continental contributions: the institution that knows what is happening across Africa before others do, that connects the data that already exists into something useful, and that helps the continent move from warning to action faster than ever before.

